sent to the boot camps of investing, mostly in or around New York, for three weeks of formal instruction.

Thanks to Ms. Garrett and her connections, Prudential-Bache allowed me to spend a few days wandering in and out of its training center in downtown Manhattan. I was also invited to stay three days and four nights at the Merrill Lynch training camp outside of Princeton, New Jersey. It took many phone calls through several departments to get this permission, but it was worth it. Merrill Lynch was the number-one retail firm, with $2 billion in assets. There were 10,000 Merrill Lynch brokers on the job already, and they trained 1,700 new ones a year to keep up with attrition.

I'd recommend their 300-room, $135-million training facility as a vacation spot. It had an Olympic-size swimming pool, racquetball courts, and a special sub-lobby just for billiards. The firm picked me up in a jasmine-scented Fugazi limousine, and assigned me a delightful double room.

The brochure on the table promised an "informal and relaxed atmosphere." Under "attire," I noted that casual clothes was the appropriate dress during the day, while normal business attire was recommended for dinner. To me, casual clothes meant shirt, pants, shoes and socks, and much less in friendly surroundings, but when I ventured out of my room in sport shirt and slacks I was met with numerous stares and a few titters. Everyone but me was wearing a business suit, and I became known as "that guy with no tie." For dinner, I changed into a blue blazer and slacks—to me, the normal business attire—only to discover that the others had changed into the kind of suit I'd wear to a funeral.

I found it curious that stockbroker trainees—many of whom were not from the monied classes—were required to dress so formally. The theory behind it, I guess, is that a stockbroker who dresses like a million dollars has a better chance convincing a real millionaire to throw some money the stockbroker's way—until the broker attracts enough of it to live up to the wardrobe. This made me think of Useful Tip Number 16:

Never trust a broker whose suit is worth more than your portfolio

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